

Arthur's Seat - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Salisbury Crag: Where Deep Time Was Discovered

The walk under Salisbury Crag takes you past one of the most important outcrops in the history of science. In the 1780s, James Hutton — Edinburgh farmer, chemist, and Enlightenment polymath — studied the junction where the Crag's dolerite sill meets the underlying sedimentary rock, and read in it something heretical: the igneous rock had been injected, molten, into pre-existing sediments, meaning the Earth was not a static creation but an engine — rocks eroding into sediment, sediment hardening, molten rock intruding, land uplifting, in cycles with, as he put it, no vestige of a beginning, no prospect of an end. Against the prevailing calculation of a roughly six-thousand-year-old Earth, Hutton's 1788 theory required essentially unlimited time, and "deep time" is arguably Scotland's greatest export to human thought — the platform on which Darwin later stood. "Hutton's Section," the spot he studied, is marked along the Radical Road, the path built beneath the Crag in 1820 to employ destitute weavers after a failed radical uprising — Walter Scott's idea — though rockfall closures have restricted it in recent years; the lower Crag path gives the same geology. The hill above is the eroded core of a Carboniferous volcano, some three hundred fifty million years old, its structure so instructively exposed by glaciation that Edinburgh became a cradle of geology partly by accident of scenery. You are hiking the textbook.

Reading the Crag, and the Quarry That Nearly Ate Them

Now that you know what Hutton found here, it's worth learning to read the crags themselves, because they're not just a backdrop, they're the evidence. Salisbury Crag is a sill: a sheet of molten rock, dolerite, that was squeezed sideways between older layers of sediment, roughly three hundred and fifty million years ago, and then cooled underground into hard, dark stone. Erosion and glaciers later stripped away the softer rock on top and in front, leaving this great tilted rampart standing proud. That hard igneous rock is what Edinburgh calls whinstone, and it matters more to this story than you'd think.

Walk round toward the south side of the hill and look up at Samson's Ribs, a run of tall, straight-sided stone columns, many of them roughly six-sided, standing shoulder to shoulder like organ pipes. They formed as a thick body of lava cooled and contracted, cracking into these regular columns, the same process that made the Giant's Causeway. It's one of the most dramatic pieces of geology in the city, and most visitors never walk round far enough to see it.

Here's the twist that nearly cost Edinburgh its most famous rocks. Whinstone is superb for paving, tough and hard-wearing, and for a long stretch of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries the Crag was quarried hard for it. An estimated two hundred and seventy thousand tonnes of stone came out of the south quarry alone, and it was shipped off to pave streets far beyond Scotland, even the streets of London. Stand back and you can still see the great bitten-out faces the quarrymen left behind. The quarrying ate its way toward the very outcrops that made this place scientifically priceless, and it caused a genuine public outcry, one of Britain's early battles to protect a landscape, until the cutting was finally stopped.

And this is where a lovely piece of the legend lives. The story goes that Hutton's Section itself, the exact junction he studied, was spared from the quarrymen at Hutton's own request, deliberately preserved so

the evidence would survive. Whether that request is strictly true or a story grown up around a great man, the section did survive, and you can walk right to it.

When you reach it, here's what to look for. You'll see a tongue of the dark dolerite reaching down into paler, layered sedimentary rock beneath, and, if you look closely, thin fingers of the igneous rock injected into the sediment. That's the whole argument in a single view. The molten rock is clearly younger, forcing its way into layers that were already there. To Hutton's eye, that meant heat, movement, and above all time, oceans of it. You are looking at the actual outcrop that helped unshackle the age of the Earth.

The Radical Road and the Royal Wilderness

Look down to the foot of the crags and you'll pick out a made path running along beneath that towering wall of rock. That's the Radical Road, and its name carries one of the sharpest little stories in the park. In 1820, Scotland was raw with unrest. A short-lived rising, remembered as the Radical War, had just been put down, and among those left jobless and desperate were weavers from the west of the country, skilled cloth-workers whose trade was collapsing. To give some of them honest work, and perhaps to keep idle, angry hands busy, they were set to building this path along the base of Salisbury Crags. The suggestion, fittingly for Edinburgh, came from the novelist Walter Scott. So a road named for radicals was built by the very men the authorities most feared, stone by stone, beneath these cliffs.

There's a modern coda. Rockfall from the crags above has made the Radical Road genuinely hazardous, and it has been closed to walkers since 2018, with boulders coming down onto the very path those weavers laid. The lower paths still give you the same sweep of geology, so you lose nothing but the closest approach.

Now lift your eyes from that one path to the whole park around you, because its wildness is a kind of illusion. This has been royal ground for the better part of nine hundred years. Down below sits Holyrood, and the name itself means holy cross. King David the First founded Holyrood Abbey here in 1128, and the legend has him charging a stag on this very ground and being saved by a miraculous cross appearing between its antlers. True or not, the crown kept the land, and these hills became a royal hunting park, a place for kings to chase deer within sight of their palace.

In 1541 King James the Fifth had the park formally enclosed within a stone wall, fixing its boundaries much as they run today, and turning a stretch of open hill into a defined royal preserve. Over the centuries that followed, this same ground served as hunting chase, as parade ground where troops were reviewed, as duelling field where gentlemen settled quarrels at dawn, and, as the Radical Road reminds us, as a place to park the poor and the dangerous with a shovel and a task.

So the paradox of Arthur's Seat is that this rugged, rabbit-run, dragon-shaped wilderness in the heart of a capital city is not wild at all. It's a royal backyard that simply refused to be tamed into lawns and flowerbeds, a piece of raw Scotland that the monarchy fenced but never civilised. You're hiking a king's hunting ground that happens to be an extinct volcano, and it has worn every one of those roles without losing its nerve.

The Fort, the Terraces, and the View

Geology made this hill, but people have been climbing it for their own reasons for thousands of years, and the summit you're aiming for is not empty history. It's crowned by an Iron Age hillfort. Look along the eastern side for two low stony banks, the eroded ramparts of a fortification that barred the approach up the broad gully into the saddle between the main peak and Crow Hill beside it. And this fort has company: Holyrood Park held four hilltop strongholds in all, on Dunsapie, on Crow Hill, above Samson's Ribs, and on the Salisbury Crags themselves, a remarkably crowded prehistoric skyline. These were strongholds of the Votadini, the people later remembered in the early Welsh poem *Y Gododdin*, composed around the year six hundred, which mourns warriors who feasted in a hall near here and rode south to die in battle.

Before you leave the human landscape, look at the eastern slopes when the light rakes across them low and golden. You'll see long, level steps terracing the hillside, best viewed from the Duddingston side. Those are cultivation terraces, cut by farmers to win flat, ploughable ground from a steep hill, and they're among the best-preserved examples in the Lothians. Most walkers march straight past two thousand years of agriculture without a glance.

Now, the reward. From the two-hundred-and-fifty-one-metre summit, the panorama is genuinely one of the finest in Britain, and worth orienting yourself properly. To the west, the Old Town streams down its ridge to Edinburgh Castle, perched on a volcanic plug that is a close geological cousin of the rock beneath your boots. To the north lies the broad Firth of Forth and, beyond it, the Kingdom of Fife, with the Forth bridges strung across the water some twelve miles off on a clear day. Swing east toward the sea and pick out the Bass Rock, a pale dome that is itself an old volcanic core, whitened each summer by one of the world's great gannet colonies, with the cone of North Berwick Law nearby, another volcanic remnant. To the south rise the green Pentland Hills, and on a rare, sparkling day you can catch the blue edge of the Highlands far to the north-west.

A word on the practical, because this is a real mountain in miniature. There are two very different ways up. The gentle option is the path traversing beneath Salisbury Crag, mostly level, huge on views, easy on the legs. The summit itself asks for a proper walk and a short rocky scramble, most kindly approached from the Dunsapie side to the east. And heed the rock: this dark basalt turns treacherously slick in the wet, so if the weather is against you, take the Crag path and save the summit for a dry day. Go early, and you may have the ramparts of the fort almost to yourself.

Arthur, Miniature Coffins, and a Park Full of Stories

Holyrood Park packs an improbable amount of legend into a royal backyard. The name Arthur's Seat is first recorded in the fifteenth century and its origin is genuinely unknown — the King Arthur connection is likely folk etymology, though Welsh-language tradition does place the historical Arthur's milieu in southern Scotland's Old North, so romantics are not entirely without a case. St Anthony's Chapel, the gaunt ruin above St Margaret's Loch, is a medieval hermitage of obscure purpose with commanding views of the Forth. May Day tradition has Edinburgh residents climbing the hill at dawn to wash their faces in the dew for beauty and luck — still practiced. And then there are the coffins: in June 1836, boys hunting rabbits on the hill's northeast slope found a concealed recess containing seventeen miniature coffins, each holding a dressed, carved wooden figure. Contemporary theories ran from witchcraft to sailors' charms; the modern favorite, argued in detail by researchers at the National Museum, links them to Burke and Hare's sixteen murder victims of 1827 to 28, plus the first, naturally dead body they sold — seventeen bodies denied burial, since dissection destroyed them, perhaps given surrogate funerals by someone who knew them, or knew guilt. Analysis suggests one maker, possibly a shoemaker by his tools, working around the right date. Eight coffins survive in the National Museum of Scotland. It remains unsolved, and it's a fittingly Edinburgh mystery: half science, half grave-robbing gothic, found by kids on a volcano.

The Coffins as Objects: What the Evidence Actually Says

Strip away the ghost-story glamour for a moment and look at the seventeen coffins as physical evidence, because the objects themselves are more eloquent than any theory. They were found in late June 1836, on the north-eastern slope of this hill, by boys hunting for rabbits, tucked into a small hollow and sealed behind three thin, pointed pieces of slate arranged like a little doorway. Not scattered, not dumped. Deliberately concealed and neatly stowed.

Each coffin is small, about ninety-five millimetres long, carved from a single block of wood and fitted with a lid. Whoever made them decorated the exteriors with lozenge-shaped pieces of tin, pressed into the surface in a regular pattern, so these were not careless offcuts but finished, considered things. Inside each lay a carved wooden figure, and here the detail turns telling. The figures appear to have begun life as toy soldiers, mass-produced little men, some of which had their arms cut away so they would lie flat in the box, then dressed in individually stitched and glued cloth garments. Someone took the cheerful and made it funereal, one figure at a time, seventeen times over.

The most careful modern study is the one to lean on. In 1994, in the *Book of the Old Edinburgh Club*, Samuel Menefee and Allen Simpson published the definitive analysis, and later museum examination has refined it. Their reading of the tool marks suggests a single maker, someone accustomed to working with sharp metal tools, plausibly in a trade like shoemaking or leatherwork rather than fine cabinetry, since the joinery is workmanlike rather than delicate. The style of the stitched clothing hints that the burials may have been assembled over a period of time rather than in one sitting, which is itself a clue about intent.

Eight of the seventeen survive, and even their afterlife is well documented. They passed through private hands and a sale, and in 1901 a woman named Christina Couper of Tynron, in Dumfriesshire, donated her eight coffins to what is now the National Museum of Scotland, where they remain on display. That good provenance is part of why these particular objects have never been dismissed as a hoax. Too much careful, consistent, laborious work went into them for a prank.

Here is the honest boundary, though, and it matters. Everything past the objects is inference. There is no note, no confession, no contemporary document naming a maker or a motive. The famous link to Burke and Hare, which the next chapter takes up, rests on a coincidence of numbers and a matching of dates,

not on proof. The coffins are real, their craftsmanship is real, their careful concealment is real. The story we hang on them is a hypothesis, the best we have, and a good docent will always tell you where the evidence stops and the storytelling begins.

The Park's Other Ghosts: Chapels, Cairns, and a Skating Minister

The coffins are the park's most famous mystery, but Holyrood Park is thick with quieter stories, and it rewards a walker who knows where to look. Start with the gaunt ruin on the rocky shoulder above St Margaret's Loch. That is St Anthony's Chapel, medieval, roofless now, with a single tall fragment still standing. Its exact origins are genuinely obscure, which is unusual for a stone building of any size. It may have been linked to a hospital of St Anthony down at Leith, or served pilgrims, or simply provided a dramatic place of devotion above the loch, its light kept as a guide for ships on the Forth. Below it once flowed St Anthony's Well, one of several springs on the hill that drew people seeking cures and, on the right morning, a little luck.

That luck brings us to a custom people still keep. On the first dawn of May, Edinburgh folk climb the hill to wash their faces in the morning dew, in an old belief that it brings beauty and good fortune for the year. It is one of the few genuinely surviving folk rituals of the city, and if you're here at the right season you'll find the summit strangely busy at first light.

Now for something darker. Somewhere on the low ground stands Muschat's Cairn, a heap of stones marking a real and grim event: the murder in 1720 of Margaret Muschat by her husband Nicol, whose name the cairn still carries. Walter Scott seized on the spot and made it unforgettable in his novel *The Heart of Midlothian*, setting a tense night-time meeting there, so the cairn now lives a double life, half true crime, half literary landmark. This is very Edinburgh, a real horror polished into a story you can visit.

And keep an eye on the shape of the hill itself, because the folklore insists it is a sleeping dragon, gorged and curled and turned to stone, its long spine the ridge you climb. It's a modern-ish tale rather than ancient gospel, but stand at the right angle and you'll see exactly why people tell it.

End on a gentler note, down at Duddingston Loch at the hill's south-eastern foot. This quiet water is the likely setting of one of Scotland's best-loved paintings, *The Skating Minister*, showing the Reverend Robert Walker gliding across the ice, long attributed to Sir Henry Raeburn and painted around the seventeenth nineties, though some scholars now question whose hand it truly was. The original hangs in the Scottish National Gallery. So this single park gives you a haunted chapel, a wishing well, a murder immortalised in fiction, a stone dragon, and a national masterpiece on frozen water, all before you've even reached the summit.

Arthur, Camelot, and the Old North

It's worth confronting the name head-on, because everyone wants Arthur's Seat to mean what it says, and the truth is both more uncertain and more interesting. The name is first recorded only in the fifteenth century, and its real origin is unknown. The romantic link to King Arthur, with a whisper of Camelot and knights asleep beneath the hill, is almost certainly folk etymology, a later ear making comfortable sense of an older, stranger word. Rival guesses abound. Some derive it from Gaelic, along the lines of Àrd-na-Said, a phrase read as the height of arrows or the height of the ridge. Others prefer a plainer Archer's Seat. The honest position is that these are all conjecture, and no one has settled it. The hill kept its oldest name to itself.

But here's the twist that gives the Arthurian dream a flicker of legitimacy. This region really was, in the centuries after Rome withdrew, the heartland of a heroic warrior culture, and it spoke a Brythonic language, a cousin of Welsh, not yet the Scots or Gaelic we might expect. Historians call this vanished world the Old North. The people here were the Votadini, later remembered as the Gododdin, and their

great stronghold, Din Eidyn, most likely stood on the Castle Rock across the valley from you, the fortified seed from which Edinburgh itself grew.

From that world comes one of the oldest surviving pieces of literature composed in Britain, the poem *Y Gododdin*, attributed to the bard Aneirin and reaching back to around the year six hundred. It commemorates a war band of picked warriors who feasted and drank in the hall at Din Eidyn for a year, then rode south to attack their enemies at a place called Catraeth, where nearly all of them were killed. It is elegy, not chronicle, a roll-call of the beautiful doomed, and it belongs to these very hills. Tantalisingly, the poem contains a passing comparison of one hero to Arthur, one of the earliest mentions of that name anywhere, which is not proof of a real king but does show the legend was already in the air in exactly this landscape.

So set the fantasy of Camelot gently aside, and pick up something better. You are standing in the Old North, on ground held by a real Brythonic warrior aristocracy whose deeds were sung when the memory of Rome was still fresh. Their neighbours held other volcanic strongholds you can see from here, like Traprain Law away to the east. The name on the map may be a medieval misunderstanding, but the heroic age it accidentally points to was real, and it happened right where you're standing. That, in the end, is the pattern of this whole hill: reach for the legend, and you fall through it into something older, stranger, and true.